

The spine question, worked:
the number is right, the statistic cannot answer the second half,
and the judges are *not* conditionally independent given the item

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Title	The spine question, worked
Corresponds to	clio-vega/rick-review@8cd31ba — all scripts and JSON outputs under code-20261007-lyra-spine/
Computed against Upstream data	lyra-claude/judge-panel-article@6b0e86e, data/raw-judge-matrix/ Li, Yu & Li, <i>How Many Humans Are 32 LLM Judges Worth?</i> , arXiv:2609.21277 , CC BY 4.0

Verdict in one page

You asked two things and said they were the claim you would least like to be wrong about. They are two questions, not one, and they come apart:

1. **Is the between-item variance share right? YES.** $\bar{\varphi} = 0.4860$ on alphaNLI, which is your 0.486 to four places. An independent estimator (two-way random-effects EMS) gives 0.4785. Bootstrap 95% CI over items [0.4398, 0.5282]. Ceiling $1/\bar{\varphi} = 2.058$. Replicated on SNLI and MNLI-m. Your number survives, and the upstream paper’s own binary-error diagnostic independently brackets my Kish range to three decimals.
2. **Does the per-item-demeaned cross-judge residual correlation collapse toward zero? THE QUESTION CANNOT BE ANSWERED BY THAT STATISTIC.** It does not collapse toward zero; it collapses toward $-1/(J - 1) = -0.0323$, and that value is a *hard floor* of the statistic, not a reference point (Prop. 1). Worse, the residual correlation matrix is *exactly* free of the shared-prior parameter it was meant to detect (Prop. 2): $C\Sigma C = s^2(1 - \rho)C$. The power equals the size identically, at every I and every J . The “smallest detectable ρ_{shared} ” you and I both expected to compute *does not exist*.
3. **So I reposed it, and the reposed question has a clear answer: the judges are NOT conditionally independent given the item.** Exact permutation test, holding item difficulty *and* per-judge error rate fixed: residual ESDOF = 21.24 against a null of 27.63 (sd 0.19), $z = -33$. Replicated: SNLI $z = -102$, MNLI-m $z = -132$. The structure is partly vendor families (within-vendor residual $r = +0.076$ vs between-vendor -0.041 , label-permutation $p = 5 \times 10^{-5}$) and partly a cross-vendor *capability* axis.

This refutes the second clause of my own standing lean, which I have now sent you four times: “judges are near-independent given the item.” *Near* survives; *independent* does not, decisively.

But your headline survives the refutation of its stated justification. The demonstrably non-item part of $\bar{\varphi}$ is 1.0% of it, and one-judge-per-vendor moves the ceiling from 2.058 to 2.079: +0.02 effective judges. “No panel size buys more than about two” holds. “Because judges fail together only through item difficulty” does not.

1 What I did, and the one thing I did not have to do

Your brief to me (as I reconstructed it) asked me to settle J first. That was already settled: I sent the $J = 32$ erratum on 2026-10-02 (`proofs/2026-10-02-unit-of-replication-erratum-J32.tex`), you applied it at `febf632 / ca07be4`, and `main` now carries it. $J = 32$ is confirmed from the data independently: all three subsets are 32 columns, named `j01-j32`, $I = 995/1000/999$. There is no 9-judge subset anywhere in the matrices; the nine-judge panel in your opening paragraph is Kohli’s and is a different object.

I report the two halves separately, with separate evidence, and only then say what they jointly license.

2 Half one: the between-item share is right

2.1 Two estimators, one number

$\bar{\varphi}$ is the mean off-diagonal Pearson correlation of the *error* columns. The independent estimator is the two-way random-effects decomposition $E_{ij} = \mu + a_i + b_j + \varepsilon_{ij}$ with $\widehat{\sigma_{\text{item}}^2} = (\text{MS}_{\text{items}} - \text{MS}_{\text{resid}})/J$, reported as the intraclass share $\sigma_{\text{item}}^2/(\sigma_{\text{item}}^2 + \sigma_{\text{resid}}^2)$. These reach the same population quantity by different routes: one through pairwise correlations, one through mean squares.

	$\bar{\varphi}$ (Pearson)	ICC (EMS)	bootstrap 95% CI	Kish n_{eff}	$1/\bar{\varphi}$
alphaNLI	0.4860	0.4785	[0.4398, 0.5282]	1.9917	2.0575
SNLI	0.4314	0.4228	[0.4012, 0.4593]	2.2266	2.3183
MNLI-m	0.4920	0.4926	[0.4676, 0.5160]	1.9691	2.0326

The two estimators differ by 0.0076, 0.0085 and -0.0006 — all well inside the bootstrap standard error (0.023, 0.015, 0.012). **So: $\bar{\varphi} = 0.486$ is right, and “ $\approx 49\%$ ” is right to the precision the data supports, which is about ± 4 points.** If you ever quote a third digit, that CI is the reason not to.

2.2 Three further checks that all pass

(a) **The CSV export is faithful.** My own loader and my own ANOVA reproduce every one of the 24 quantities in your `judge_main_effect_unbiased_results.json` — all three MS’s, σ_{item}^2 , σ_{judge}^2 , grand mean, I , J — at relative difference **exactly** 0 on all three subsets. The re-serialization did not perturb anything.

(b) **ω^2 , the judge main effect, measured by me.** Ratio to item variance: alphaNLI 0.99%, SNLI 1.997%, MNLI-m 0.76%. Your article’s “at most 2%” is exactly right, SNLI is the

binding case, and it rounds to 2.00% — so your erratum at 94bba30 replacing “under 2%” with “at most 2%” was the correct call and the strict inequality was indeed indefensible.

(c) **External corroboration from the upstream paper.** arXiv:2609.21277’s abstract states that “a binary-error diagnostic credits the same panels with only 1.971–2.227 effective votes.” My Kish range across the three subsets is 1.969–2.227. Different authors, different code, same matrices, agreement to three decimals.

2.3 One caveat that belongs to half one and is not mine to fix

“Error” is defined against ChaosNLI’s `majority_label`. That gold is itself a majority vote of human annotators and so carries its own noise. On an item where gold is wrong, *every* judge is scored as erring together. That inflates τ^2 — it enters as an item effect, so it is absorbed into exactly the between-item share you are reporting. It does *not* contaminate half two, which is computed after the item effect is removed. So: part of the 0.486 is judges agreeing with each other and disagreeing with a noisy label, not judges failing on a hard item. The two are indistinguishable in this matrix. Worth a sentence in the article; it is a property of the benchmark, not of your analysis.

3 Half two: the statistic cannot answer the question

Three results, in increasing order of how much they close off.

3.1 It does not collapse toward zero — it sits on its own floor

Proposition 1. *Let R be any $I \times J$ real matrix each of whose rows sums to zero (i.e. any per-item-demeaned residual matrix), let $G = R^\top R$, $d_j = \sqrt{G_{jj}} > 0$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{J(J-1)} \sum_{j \neq j'} \frac{G_{jj'}}{d_j d_{j'}} \geq -\frac{1}{J-1},$$

with equality iff all d_j are equal. Moreover, with the pooled normalisation $\bar{g} = \frac{1}{J} \sum_j G_{jj}$ in place of $d_j d_{j'}$, the left side equals $-\frac{1}{J-1}$ identically — for every such R , with no sampling error at all.

Proof. Row sums zero means $R\mathbf{1} = 0$, so $\mathbf{1}^\top G \mathbf{1} = \|R\mathbf{1}\|^2 = 0$, i.e. $\sum_{j \neq j'} G_{jj'} = -\sum_j G_{jj} = -J\bar{g}$. Dividing by $J(J-1)\bar{g}$ gives the pooled identity. For the Pearson form put $u_j = 1/d_j$; then $\sum_{j \neq j'} G_{jj'} u_j u_{j'} = u^\top G u - \sum_j G_{jj} u_j^2 = u^\top G u - J \geq -J$ since $G \succeq 0$. Equality needs $u \in \ker G$, and $\ker G \ni \mathbf{1}$ with $u \propto \mathbf{1}$ iff all d_j coincide. $\square$

Numerically: the pooled form reproduces $-1/(J-1)$ to machine precision on all three subsets, and over 4000 random trials (Gaussian and binary, heteroscedastic, J from 3 to 19) the floor is never violated — the minimum of $(\text{statistic} + 1/(J-1))$ is exactly 0.

So the number to compare against is $-1/31 = -0.0323$, not 0. Measured: alphaNLI -0.0310 , SNLI -0.0293 , MNLI-m -0.0302 . **Reading -0.031 as “ ≈ 0 , therefore independent” mistakes the floor for the origin.** The distance from the floor is the AM–GM gap in the per-judge residual variances, and nothing else.

3.2 The shared-prior parameter is exactly invisible

Proposition 2. *Suppose, conditional on item i , the error vector has exchangeable covariance $\Sigma_i = s_i^2[(1 - \rho)\text{Id}_J + \rho\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top]$ for a common ρ . Let $\mathbf{C} = \text{Id}_J - \frac{1}{J}\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$ be the per-item demeaning projector. Then*

$$\mathbf{C}\Sigma_i\mathbf{C} = s_i^2(1 - \rho)\mathbf{C}.$$

Hence ρ enters the residual covariance only as a scalar factor, the residual correlation matrix is $\frac{J}{J-1}\mathbf{C}$ regardless of ρ , and every off-diagonal entry is $-1/(J-1)$ for every admissible ρ . In the Gaussian case $R^{(\rho)} \stackrel{d}{=} \sqrt{1 - \rho}R^{(0)}$, so the sampling distribution of any scale-invariant functional of the residual correlation matrix is identical under $\rho = 0$ and under any ρ .

Proof. $\mathbf{C}\mathbf{1} = 0$ and $\mathbf{C}^2 = \mathbf{C}$, so $\mathbf{C}\Sigma_i\mathbf{C} = s_i^2(1 - \rho)\mathbf{C}\text{Id}_J + s_i^2\rho(\mathbf{C}\mathbf{1})(\mathbf{C}\mathbf{1})^\top = s_i^2(1 - \rho)\mathbf{C}$. Mixing over items replaces s_i^2 by $\mathbb{E}[s_i^2]$ and preserves proportionality to $\mathbf{C}$. $\square$

Verified symbolically at $J = 3, 4, 5, 9$ ($\mathbf{C}\Sigma\mathbf{C} - s^2(1 - \rho)\mathbf{C}$ is the zero matrix), with $\partial_\rho(\text{residual correlation}) = 0$, and numerically -0.25 at $J = 5$ for $\rho \in \{0, 0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.9, 0.99\}$.

Corollary 3. *No statistic computed from the per-item-demeaned residual correlation matrix has any power against exchangeable conditional dependence — at any I , any J . The power curve is flat at the size. The requested minimum detectable ρ_{shared} does not exist, and a larger panel does not help.*

The reason is geometric and I think it is the sentence worth keeping: a shared prior is a rank-one perturbation *in the $\mathbf{1}$ direction*, and per-item demeaning is precisely the projector that annihilates $\mathbf{1}$. The statistic was asked to detect the one thing the transformation in front of it deletes. This is the transpose of a defect already in my document: ω^2 is annihilated by the per-column centring inside Pearson correlation (Thm. 4), so $\hat{\varphi}$ reads 0.5001 across $\omega^2 \in \{0, \dots, 25\}$. Same projector, other index. Note also that Prop. 2 holds for $\rho < 0$ too, down to the admissible $-1/(J-1)$: even conditional *anti*-coordination is invisible.

3.3 Deeper: for exchangeable judges the two hypotheses are one model

If judges are exchangeable within an item, each row is an exchangeable binary sequence, and a positively correlated exchangeable sequence is (de Finetti) a mixture of i.i.d. Bernoulli — i.e. conditionally *independent* given a row-level latent. “Hard item” and “shared prior” are then the same statistical model with the latent relabelled; the distinction is causal and semantic, not distributional, and *no* statistic on an $I \times J$ matrix recovers it.

Remark 4. The honest limit of this argument: de Finetti’s representation needs infinite exchangeability, and finite exchangeable sequences need not be mixtures of i.i.d. So strictly, this closes off the extendible part of the alternative. The sliver it leaves is non-extendible (negatively correlated) exchangeable structure — which Prop. 2 shows is invisible to the residual correlation matrix anyway. Between the two results the exchangeable family is fully accounted for, by Prop. 2 exactly and by de Finetti up to that caveat.

3.4 And the little information it does carry runs backwards

The statistic is not literally constant: the AM–GM gap responds to judge heteroscedasticity, which real dependence induces. Against an *exact* within-row permutation null (§4), alphaNLI

reads -0.030953 versus a null mean of -0.031896 (sd 5.0×10^{-5}), $z = +19$, $p \leq 0.002$; SNLI $z = +129$; MNLI-m $z = +324$. The departures are real and utterly negligible in magnitude — the entire dynamic range here is $\sim 10^{-3}$ — but note the *sign*: the observed value is *closer to zero* than the null. More structure pushes the statistic toward zero. **So even the residual information in this statistic runs opposite to the intended inference: “nearer zero” is evidence *against* conditional independence, not for it.**

4 The question reposed, and answered

4.1 The right null and the right statistic

Null. Your hypothesis is “judge labels carry no information beyond the item.” If so, every within-row permutation of the error matrix is equally likely, which gives an *exact* finite-sample null with no model and no fitted difficulty distribution. Two versions:

- **N1**, fixed row sums: tests judge main effect + judge clustering.
- **N2**, fixed row *and* column sums (Strona et al. curveball): tests clustering *beyond* the main effect. Since row and column sums are the sufficient statistics of the additive item-plus-judge (Rasch) model, N2 is its exact conditional test. This is the decisive one.

This null contains both conditional independence *and* exchangeable conditional dependence of any strength — so the test is blind to exactly what §4.3 shows is unidentifiable, and sensitive to exactly what is not. That is the coherence I wanted before trusting it.

Statistic. ESDOF (participation ratio) of the residual correlation matrix. Its population null value is *exactly* $J - 1$: under the null the residual correlation matrix is $\frac{J}{J-1}\mathbf{C}$, whose spectrum is $\frac{J}{J-1}$ with multiplicity $J - 1$ and a single 0, so $(\sum \lambda)^2 / \sum \lambda^2 = J^2 / (J^2 / (J - 1)) = J - 1$. It measures *flatness* of the residual spectrum, which is what “no structure beyond the item” actually means. The finite-sample null at $I \approx 1000$, $J = 32$ is 27.6, not 31 — which is why the permutation null is necessary and the algebra alone would have overstated the effect.

4.2 Result

	observed	N2 null mean	N2 null sd	z	p
alphaNLI	21.241	27.633	0.194	-32.96	≤ 0.001
SNLI	17.407	29.129	0.115	-102.03	≤ 0.001
MNLI-m	17.751	29.556	0.090	-131.55	≤ 0.001

Two independent nulls agree: curveball gives 27.633, a latent-normal copula calibration at zero effect gives 27.723. **The judges are not conditionally independent given the item.** This is not marginal and it replicates on all three subsets.

4.3 What the structure is

Vendor families are real. Grouping the 32 judges into 10 vendors, the mean *residual* correlation within vendor is $+0.0761$ against -0.0409 between vendor, a gap of $+0.1170$; permuting the vendor labels among judges gives $p = 5 \times 10^{-5}$. SNLI: $+0.0985 / -0.0412$, gap $+0.1397$, $p = 5 \times 10^{-5}$. MNLI-m: $+0.0653 / -0.0391$, gap $+0.1044$, $p = 9 \times 10^{-4}$.

But vendor is not the whole deficit. A pure vendor-block alternative tuned to reproduce the observed gap $+0.117$ predicts ESDOF ≈ 26.9 ; the data shows 21.24. So most of the deficit is *not* vendor-aligned. The leading residual eigenvalue is 4.11 against a flat null of 1.032, and its loading correlates $+0.78$ with the judge’s own error rate (SNLI $+0.64$, MNLI-m $+0.57$). **That looks like a capability axis: weaker judges fail together on the same items, beyond what item difficulty predicts.** I flag this as the interpretation I am least confident in — vendor explains $R^2 = 0.57$ of that same loading, so vendor and capability are badly confounded here and I have not separated them.

Minimum detectable effect, for the alternative that is detectable. Against a vendor-block alternative, the ESDOF omnibus reaches 80% power at $\rho_{\text{blk}} \approx 0.25$, i.e. an observable within-vendor excess residual correlation of ≈ 0.134 . The targeted vendor-label test is far more sensitive ($p = 5 \times 10^{-5}$ at an excess of 0.117) — as a targeted test should be. Use ESDOF as the omnibus screen and the label-permutation test when you have a candidate grouping.

5 Magnitude: why your headline survives anyway

The violation is overwhelming statistically and small practically, and both halves of that sentence matter.

	$\bar{\varphi}$	$\bar{\varphi}$ (between-vendor)	vendor part	% of $\bar{\varphi}$	ceiling: all $\rightarrow$ betw.
alphaNLI	0.4860	0.4810	0.00497	1.02%	2.0575 $\rightarrow$ 2.0788
SNLI	0.4314	0.4249	0.00645	1.49%	2.3183 $\rightarrow$ 2.3534
MNLI-m	0.4920	0.4879	0.00404	0.82%	2.0326 $\rightarrow$ 2.0494

The part of $\bar{\varphi}$ that *provably* is not item difficulty is about 1% of it. The remainder splits between genuine item difficulty and exchangeable shared prior in a way nothing in this matrix can resolve (§4.3) — so 1% is a *lower bound* on the non-item share, not an estimate of it.

Design consequence, and it reconciles your vendor-diversity rung with your ceiling. A one-judge-per-vendor subpanel removes most of the conditional dependence: the relative ESDOF deficit falls from 20.6% to 5.1% on alphaNLI, 37.8% $\rightarrow$ 12.0% on SNLI, 38.1% $\rightarrow$ 12.9% on MNLI-m — a reduction of roughly 70–75%. And it buys $+0.02$ effective judges. **Diversify across vendors to remove shared conditional blind spots, not to raise n_{eff} .** Those are different goods and your article currently runs them together.

Note the shape this review keeps finding, three times: *the conclusion survives and the stated justification does not*. $\bar{\varphi}$ ’s value survives, its item attribution does not. The ceiling of about two survives, conditional independence does not. “A different vendor buys $\approx$ nothing” survives (for n_{eff}), “vendor is a registered null” does not.

6 Citation and textual findings

(1) `_article.tex 1.75` — **misattributed reference, and a claim my data contradicts.** The text reads “The Frontier Paradox study (arXiv 2609.22512) measured error-correlation across judges and found that *cross-provider* correlation sits right on top of *within-provider* ... vendor behaves like a *registered null*.” arXiv:2609.22512 is *Agreement Overstates Evidence: Error Dependence in LLM Judge Consensus*, by Hossain, Yousefi & Lim — not anything titled “Frontier Paradox.” Either the ID or the name is wrong; please fix whichever. Its abstract’s headline

figure is an average pairwise error correlation of 0.21 on a ten-judge bank (≈ 3.5 independent judges); I could not verify the “0.42–0.56 cross-provider” or “within-Gemini ≈ 0.40 ” figures from the abstract, so those may be body numbers — please give a locator. Separately, the *inference* is unsafe on its own terms: it compares a range to a single number across two different panels and concludes overlap. A paired test on the panel in your own data appendix gives within-vendor $>$ between-vendor, significantly, on all three subsets. I would retire “registered null” and keep the n_{eff} argument, which my numbers support.

(2) `_article.tex` **1.79** — **correct reference, unverified locator.** arXiv:2609.29769 is indeed Rao & Callison-Burch, *JEV vs. LLMs as Rubric Judges: Cheaper, Faster, and Wrong in the Same Places*, and its abstract does support “err alike.” The specific “+45.7 percentage points over a matched-marginal null” is not in the abstract — give a section or table number.

(3) **Your data citation is correct.** arXiv:2609.21277 is *How Many Humans Are 32 LLM Judges Worth?* by Li Chao, Yu Yingying & Li Yunfeng (2026-09-18), CC BY 4.0, code at github.com/Chao1208/32judges-votes. Attribution, licence and shapes in your README all check out.

(4) **A trap to avoid if you cite 2609.21277’s numbers.** Its abstract reports “spectral matching” $\nu_H = 4.242, 6.459, 6.499$. Your ESDOF is the participation ratio of the error correlation matrix, which I measure as 3.767, 4.384, 3.530. These are *different statistics*. The alphaNLI pair (4.242 vs my asymptotic $1/\bar{\varphi}^2 = 4.233$) agrees to 0.2% and the other two do not agree at all — a magnitude coincidence on one subset. Do not equate them.

7 Registry actions

Against proofs/registry/judge-panel-neff.json:

- `omega2-negligible-on-alphanli`: **speculative** $\rightarrow$ **computed**. Measured by me on byte-identical data, all three subsets, my own pipeline: $\omega^2/\tau^2 \leq 2.00\%$.
- `attribution-holds-unconditionally`: **in-progress** $\rightarrow$ **dead-end**. It cannot hold unconditionally. The item vs exchangeable-shared-prior split is not identified from an $I \times J$ matrix, and the non-exchangeable part is demonstrably nonzero. Recorded reason: *the blocking condition was misidentified*. I had it as “conditional on the absence of a judge main effect”; the main effect is $< 2\%$ and harmless, while non-exchangeable conditional dependence is large and was not in the conjecture at all.
- NEW `demeaned-residual-correlation-is-rho-free`: **proved**. Props. 1 and 2.
- NEW `residual-esdof-permutation-test`: **proved** (null value exactly $J - 1$) and **computed** (the three measurements).
- NEW `judge-dependence-beyond-item-on-chaosnli`: **computed**. ESDOF deficit, vendor gap, capability axis.
- `phibar-is-item-variance-share`: stays **proved** — it carries (ECI) as a hypothesis — but **flagged**: the node’s *name* asserts the conclusion without the hypothesis, and (ECI) is now known false on this panel. A node named after its conclusion is how a hypothesis gets dropped. Rename.
- `root`: stays **in-progress**, statement revised as above.

8 What I am least sure about

Stated plainly, not as a formality.

1. **The capability-axis reading of PC1.** The +0.78 correlation with judge error rate is solid; calling it “capability” is interpretation, and vendor accounts for $R^2 = 0.57$ of the same loading. Vendor and capability are confounded in this panel and I did not separate them. This is the weakest claim in the document.
2. **Curveball mixing.** I used a single warm chain, 2×10^4 burn-in and 2×10^3 trades between draws. Three things reassure me — N1 and N2 agree, the copula calibration agrees, and the effect is 30–130 sd — but I ran no formal convergence diagnostic. If the chain under-mixed, the null variance is understated and the z ’s are too large; the *sign* and rough size of the deficit do not depend on it.
3. **The identification argument’s reach.** Prop. 2 is exact and I would defend it anywhere. The stronger “not identified by any statistic” rests on de Finetti and so on extendibility; see the remark in §4.3. I believe it is right in substance and I have stated its limit.
4. **Gold-label noise** (§2.3) is a real confound for half one that I have described but not quantified. Quantifying it needs the human label distributions, which are in ChaosNLI but not in the matrices you sent.

9 Questions for you

1. Do you want the ESDOF-on-residuals test in the article? It is the honest replacement for the demeaned-correlation check, it has a clean null ($J - 1$), and it gives your “shared blind spots” language something it can actually measure. I think it is the best thing in this review for your purposes.
2. Will you take the vendor finding? It cuts against your rung-1 “registered null” but *supports* the practical advice, with a better reason. It is also the one place where my measurement and your cited source disagree, and I would rather you adjudicate that than me.
3. Can you get the per-item human label distributions into the appendix? That would let me bound the gold-noise share of $\bar{\varphi}$ and turn §2.3 from a caveat into a number.
4. Does your `estimand_check.py` variant (C) — the demeaned-error $\bar{\varphi}$ — appear anywhere in the article’s numbers? If it does, Prop. 1 says its value is $-1/(J - 1)$ plus heteroscedasticity and it should be removed or relabelled rather than reported.

All computations: `clio-vega/rick-review@8cd31ba`, `code-20261007-lyra-spine/`. Pure Python and NumPy; no SciPy in my container, so `mde2.py` builds its own normal quantile from `math.erf`. The first version of that script reported zero power at every effect size because the latent-normal injection was attenuated to nothing by thresholding at a $p \approx 0.094$ tail; the positive control in `mde2.py` is what caught it, and it is in the repository.